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ON AUGUST 21, two days before National Space Day, the founders of 20 space start-ups, including Skyroot, Agnikul, Pixxel, Dhruva Space, Bellatrix, Digantara and GalaxEye, gathered at Seva Teerth in New Delhi to meet Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The meeting offered a snapshot of how far India's private space industry had come: from an idea to orbit.

It began as a working session, with actual hardware on the table. Dhruva Space showcased its P-30 platform and ground station antenna; Digantara displayed its second-generation optical payload. Around the table, the conversation turned to scale: from one rocket a month to one a week, and eventually several launches a day.

"His (PM Modi's) message to all of us was to make India the 'go-to' nation for solving space technology problems that anyone is facing anywhere in the world," Srinath Ravichandran, co-founder and CEO of Agnikul Cosmos, wrote on LinkedIn after the meeting. Modi's own message on X was that India "can offer the world a strong, innovative and commercially viable model in the space sector".